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Narendrabhai, the Man from Gujarat

Counting day in a television studio. A bit like a T20 match. Fast, furious, the excitement both real and contrived. The 16th of May 2014 was no different. It was the grand finale of the longest and most high-decibel campaign in Indian electoral history—this was the final of the Indian Political League, the biggest show in the democratic world. In the studio, we were preparing for a long day with packets of chips and orange juice to stay energized. But even before we could settle our nerves, or go for a 'strategic break', it was all over.

By 9.30 a.m., it was certain that Narendra Modi would be India's fourteenth prime minister. In our studios, Swapan Dasgupta, right-wing columnist and a proud Modi supporter, was cheering. 'It's a defining moment in Indian history,' he exulted. His sparring partner, the distinguished historian Ramachandra Guha, who disliked Modi and Rahul Gandhi in equal measure, had a firm riposte. 'I think Modi should send a thank you card to Rahul for helping him become prime minister of India!'

As we analysed the scale of the win, my mind went back to the moment when I believe it all began. The 20th of December 2012 saw another T20 match, another counting day. The results of the Gujarat and Himachal Pradesh assembly elections were streaming in that morning. Himachal was an also-ran. Gandhinagar was where the action was. By noon, we had the breaking news—Narendra Modi had scored a hat-trick in Gujarat. The margin was a bit lower than many had predicted, but with 116 seats in a 182-member assembly, Modi was once again the self-styled 'sher' of Gujarat.